UNIT 10 UNDERSTANDING CUSTOMERS

Structure

10.0 Objectives

10.1 Warm Up

10.2 Reading

10.3 Language Focus

10.4 Listening: Types of Customer

10.5 Writing

10.6 Speaking and Writing

10.7 Grammar: Relative Clauses

10.8 Pronunciation: Stress and Rhythm in Connected Speech I: Content Words and Structure Words

10.9 Let Us Sum Up

10.10 Answers

10.0 OBJECTIVES

This Unit deals in detail with the various types of customer you are likely to deal with at work. Here you will learn about:

The difference between a telephone and face-to-face business conversation

- Types of customer
- What to expect from each customer type
- How to handle each customer type
- The importance of using the right tone of voice for each customer type
- The importance of being patient in dealing with difficult customers
- Phrases to use in handling customers

10.1 WARM UP

Activity 1

Think of all the times you have gone to a store and have been confronted with a salesman whose attitude you found unpleasant. Did you find his/her tone of voice offensive, or was it his/her words that caused you to lose your temper? And were there occasions when, just because the sales person was pleasantly coaxing, you ended up buying something when you had actually only gone window shopping?

10.2 READING

As human beings we all display different characteristics, especially when under stress. In face-to-face situations, the body language and facial expressions of the person you are speaking to tells you how they are feeling, thus making it easier

for you to give appropriate responses. However, on the telephone you need to be able to recognize different types of people purely from their choice of words and their tone of voice. This is even more important for those of us who deal with customers over the telephone on a day-to-day basis.

Most customers have a specific type of product or service in mind when they make contact with an organization. They respond well to your offer to help if you do so in a positive, pleasant, and professional manner. There are others who, because of their outlook on life, their attitude, personal habits or background, may cause you frustration and require additional efforts on your part to handle them. It is this group of difficult customers that we will learn about in greater detail in this unit.

There are different kinds of difficult customers. They could be negative, rude, inconsiderate, aggressive, unreasonably demanding or too talkative. While it is not an easy task to deal with such customers, it is important to treat each one as an individual and avoid stereotyping them. Remember to stay calm and focused and not lose control of the situation.

It is also important to recognize the kind of person you are dealing with as early in the conversation as possible, as this will help you in providing an adequate response with positive results.

Types of customer



Indecisive customers: These are people who will spend hours deciding what to buy. They want to know more, but are difficult to convince, and will find excuses to avoid making a decision. Consequently, they take up a lot of your time. The way to deal with them would be to use a firm tone of voice while emphasizing the qualities of the brand you are offering. Ask a lot of open-ended questions to know exactly what their needs are so that you can offer the best possible solutions.



Reluctant customers: These, unlike the above, will listen to everything but are unwilling to make the final decision. They will even stop you from approaching the final step of buying the product or closing the call. Their typical response would be "Why don't I get back to you on this?" or "I don't have the time right now." Such customers need to be driven into making a decision. You need to make them aware of the need to buy at the opportune time by drawing their attention to the extra benefits, and special features of the product or service without being aggressive.



Demanding customers: The demanding customer generally feels the need to be in control. Such customers may raise their voice, find fault with everything, and make unreasonable demands on you. They will push you to commit to a response of their choice. They could throw tantrums and demand that their needs be met, and even accuse you of neglecting them. The important thing is to stay calm and patient and not allow their behaviour to provoke you. Be firm and assertive and focus on the customer's needs. Be flexible and willing to listen to requests, and talk about what you can

do, not about what you cannot do. Prepare to negotiate if you are thoroughly familiar with your organization's policies and procedures. Bear in mind that your ultimate goal is customer satisfaction, so provide an alternative where possible.



Rude and inconsiderate customers: They will go out of their way to be offensive. They will raise their voice, demand to see or speak to the superior, use abusive language, and snap at you. Though outwardly they seem confident and self assured, they are often insecure and defensive, and are just trying to get attention. In dealing with them, be calm, assertive and in control of the situation. Keep an even tone of voice, and if they interrupt you while you are dealing with another customer, make direct eye contact, smile and tell them firmly that you will be with them as soon as you have finished with the present customer.



Talkative customers: Such customers are friendly, chatty and expressive, and love to connect with people. They ask lots of questions. This may be because they are generally talkative, or are lonely and looking for someone to listen to them. Stay warm and friendly, ask open-ended questions to determine what they need, then switch to closed-ended questions to control the situation and limit the opportunity for the customer to continue talking. When you find the conversation slipping, ask back-on-track questions that relate to the product or service. But make sure your tone remains friendly so that you don't sound patronizing or condescending.



Passive customers: These customers listen patiently, but do not voice their own opinions, state their concerns or work towards a decision. You cannot understand or anticipate their thoughts; hence handling them is difficult since you do not know what their needs are. Their responses to what you say are usually "Ok, I see" or "Uhhhh". To understand their requirement you need to get them as involved in the conversation, and assist them to come out with their query or problem. Ask closed-ended questions to reconfirm understanding or to ask for an opinion, and also learn to read between the lines. You may also give references of other customers who were satisfied with similar solutions so that they feel confident about their decisions.



Dissatisfied customers: You will often encounter dissatisfied customers. No matter what you try to do for them, they will complain, and feel annoyed and victimized. They feel that their situation is the most important in the world. In fact these are the customers who are likely to tell the maximum number of people that they are unhappy with the way you do business. Give them uninterrupted attention while they speak – their immediate need is to know that someone is willing to attend to their problems. Do not make excuses; a dissatisfied customer does not want to hear why he did not get the service or product he wanted. It is also best to not cover the mistake, try to correct it. Empathize with him, do not patronize him. Ask open-ended questions and paraphrase the customer's responses to

acknowledge that you have understood the problem correctly, and then take appropriate action to suit his/her needs.



Irate customers: Customers can be angry for various reasons. They may be unhappy with the service, or feel they have been cheated. These customers feel the need to show anger to be taken seriously and will use their anger to intimidate you. What they really want is for you to take notice of them, give them special attention and appreciate the reason for their anger. They are also looking for explanations and solutions. The anger helps them to feel that they are the ones in control. What they do not want from you are denials, justifications, arguments, and excuses, or a condescending tone of voice and strong words.

You need to be at your professional best. Remain calm and confident. If the customer raises his/her voice or uses abusive language, take a deep breath and count to ten before responding. Remember that irate customers are angry with the organization, product, or service that you represent, not with you. Remain objective and focused on getting the information out of them that can help you sort out the problem. Following these steps will help you to tackle difficult situations with angry customers:

First of all, acknowledge their feelings and let them express themselves, then go beyond the anger and try to find the reasons for it.

- Listen actively without interrupting. Do not say anything that will further add to their anger and frustration.
- Empathize with them and reassure them that you understand why they are angry and that you want to solve their problem.
- Negotiate a solution by involving them in finding it and implement their solution if it is feasible. If not, suggest one closest to it.
- Go further and request for a written complaint via email.
- Later, conduct a follow up and ensure that everything goes well. This may require making a personal call after a period of time. Remember that the thumb rule is to under-promise but over-deliver.

Remember that a key factor that determines your success is your ability to handle various types of customer. This is where all your virtues of patience, tact, understanding and ability to use appropriate language are tested to the hilt.

Check Your Progress 1

1) Look at the statements below and write down the type of customer that you would associate each statement with.

   i) I've only got a few minutes, so I need you to attend to me immediately.

   ii) Oh, you sound a lot like a friend of mine from Pune. Have you ever been to Pune?

   iii) Why don't we take this up another time?

   iv) Can't you understand when someone tells you something once?

v) I don't think this will work.

vi) Never again will I ever use the services of your organization.

vii) It's working better now, but still not as I expected.

viii) Hmmm, perhaps.

2) Read the statements/phrases below and mark which you think are appropriate and which are inappropriate to use while dealing with difficult customers.

i) We could not furnish the details you asked for as we were short on staff.

ii) You will have to wait two days to get this information.

iii) I understand your concern…..

iv) That's not possible…..

v) I'll certainly mail it to you by tomorrow.

vi) However, what I can do is……..

vii) Our policy doesn't permit…..

viii) That's not right….

ix) I can assure you that……..

x) I can see you are upset….

xi) I'm sorry you had to deal with this billing problem. I'll do whatever I can to help you.

xii) I really want to help you solve this problem with your order

xiii) I'm not sure we can do that…

xiv) That must have been very difficult for you

xv) I think you should….

10.3 LANGUAGE FOCUS

The right language is a very powerful tool while tackling difficult situations. Especially while dealing with customers who tend to get emotionally charged and lose their temper, you need to choose your words with utmost care. Here are some example phrases that can escalate, and some that can defuse the tension in such situations.

Avoid using phrases such as these that fuel emotion

- Why didn't you…
- You should have…
- You never…
- You always…
- There is nothing I can do…
- Our policy does not permit…
- That's impossible…

- You don't realize…
- Calm down…
- I've got problems too…
- You're not the only one in a hurry…
- I've already told you a hundred times….

Instead, start your sentences with phrases like these that help to defuse anger. These are especially useful while handling irate customers.

Useful phrases such as these defuse tension

- May I explain?
- So what you would like me to do is…
- Here's what I can do…
- I'll be happy to check…
- Would you be interested in seeing…
- I understand what you're saying…/why you …
- Some people have found it helpful to…
- It's important that…
- In order for me to assist you better…
- What would you suggest……/How would you suggest we deal with….
- May I suggest……

Check Your Progress 2

Now make statements for the following situations using the appropriate phrase from the examples above.

i) You want some additional information to be able to solve a problem.

ii) You want to offer the customer something new.

iii) You want to make an important point.

iv) You are offering to go into further detail.

v) You are offering to verify something.

vi) You want to paraphrase something to show your understanding of it.

vii) You want to give the example of another satisfied customer.

viii) You want to involve the customer in finding a solution to the problem.

ix) You want to assure your customer you empathize with him.

x) You want to offer a solution.

You will have noticed that there are certain typical phrases that form the base for formal telephone conversations. The 'do you want' is replaced by 'would you like', and 'could' and 'may' are used a lot.

Activity 2

Rewrite the following sentences using phrases from the box below, to make them sound more appropriate for handling your customers. You may be able to use more than one option in some cases.

i) What did you say?

ii) When did you last call us?

iii) Can you give me your order number?

iv) What's your name?

v) I'll see what I can do.

vi) That's something I cannot do.

vii) The manager is not available at the moment.

viii) I'll call you tomorrow.

ix) I know you are not satisfied.

x) Is 2.30 p.m. on Friday okay?

Could you tell me……..	I assure you ……..
I would like……..	Could you give……
May I ……	I beg……
I would like you ……	Please……..
I'm afraid……..	Would it be……..
Would…….	Could…….

10.4 LISTENING: TYPES OF CUSTOMER

Listen to a talk about 'Types of Customer'.

Some of these customer types may be different from those in the reading section, but knowing as many of them as possible will help you deal with them better. After listening to the audio answer the following questions.

Check Your Progress 3

As you have learnt from the talk on types of customer, you need to adopt a certain type of attitude and tonal quality while dealing with different customers. Match these, numbered i-ix, to the types of customer, marked (A) - (I). Some tonal qualities may be suited to more than one customer type.

i) Be prepared with facts and figures

ii) Be encouraging and make them feel comfortable

iii) Be friendly, but restrict getting side tracked

iv) Count to ten and stay cool

v) Admit lack of awareness where necessary, and seek assistance

vi) Be patient as you may need to ask many questions to get some information

vii) Be firm to defend what is logically worth defending

viii) Be assertive, but use a calm, soothing tone of voice

ix) Use voice and words to speak with conviction

A) Aggressive

B) Extroverts

C) Analytical

D) Technically aware

E) Shy

F) Skeptical

G) Passive

H) Chronic complainers

I) Irate

10.5 WRITING

Activity 3

Look at the situations given below. Make sentences in response to the situations. Note the situations pertain to 'telephoning'.

i) Answering the telephone.

ii) Offering to take a message.

iii) Saying who you are.

iv) Asking to speak to Mrs. Jones.

v) Asking the caller for more information about the call.

vi) Saying someone is unavailable.

vii) Asking for the caller's name.

viii) Asking the caller to repeat something.

10.6 SPEAKING AND WRITING

Below are situations in which you have to make calls to a customer. With a partner, make these conversations in writing and practice them, one person playing the executive and the other the customer. Remember to use the tonal quality based on what type or customer you are, and as the executive, the tone of voice you need to take to deal with a particular type of customer. You can use the help of the phrases in the box to make the dialogue. Switch roles and practice again.

I'm positive you have not been charged…
Sorry I don't mean to inconvenience you…
Let me talk to your supervisor….
I agree that it is an inconvenience for you….
Are you certain you have the figures and dates right?
Would it be possible for you to…
I can see that this is upsetting for you…

Activity 4

1) You call a customer to collect an outstanding invoice, the amount outstanding is Rs.200, and he has defaulted on payment. The customer disputes the amount and is not willing to pay. He is also the aggressive sort.

2) A customer calls in to make a payment of Rs. 8,000 and you see that there is still Rs. 3,000 due. You need to convince her to make the additional payment as well. Being an irate customer, she loses her temper and does not want to pay the extra amount.

3) You call a customer for payment of Rs. 11,000, the customer says that he has a query on the account and refuses to pay till that is sorted out. Find out the details and collect information on the account. You have an irate customer.

4) You call up a customer to collect a payment that is due. The customer is unable to pay now due to financial problems. Your customer is shy and hesitant.

10.7 GRAMMAR: RELATIVE CLAUSES

Read the sentences given below:

1) Indecisive customers are those who will spend hours deciding what to buy.
2) Especially while dealing with customers who tend to get emotionally charged and lose their temper, you need to choose your words with utmost care.
3) The computers which/that the company bought were very expensive.
4) The candidate whom they selected had extensive experience of computer industry.
5) We are looking for an assistant whose typing speed is excellent.
6) The lady to whom I spoke in your office was very helpful.

The underlined sentences are all examples of Relative Clauses or adjectival clauses. We use a relative clause beginning with who, that, which to describe or define a person or a thing. Who is used to refer to a person, and which or that to describe or define a person.

The relative pronoun whose is used to show possession.

In formal or written language, we may insert to, from, about, on in front of whom, which and whose.

Activity 5

1) Complete the sentences with who, whom, which, that and to whom.
   i) The receptionist at the desk ……. I spoke was very helpful.
   ii) The hotel has a large conference hall in …… workshops can be held.
   iii) I can give you the name of the HR Manager ……. I deal with.
   iv) We drew a short list of candidates …….. CVs were very good.

v) We've got a machine …….. prints in colour.

vi) Yesterday I met someone …….. brother works in your office.

vii) Our client manufacturers clothing …….. is distributed in the popular retail stores.

viii) We are looking for someone …….. has a proven track record of excellence.

2) Complete the following sentences about yourself and your work, using relative clauses.

I work for a company that does event management.

i) I'm in a division ……..…….....

ii) I have a boss ……..…….....

iii) As part of my work, I deal with people …….....

iv) I sometimes have to do jobs ……..…….....

v) In my free time, I enjoy doing things……...

10.8 PRONUNCIATION: STRESS AND RHYTHM IN CONNECTED SPEECH I: CONTENT WORDS AND STRUCTURE WORDS

In Connected Speech we put words together to form phrases and sentences. For example, 'rice and curd' is a phrase and 'I am a student' is a sentence. When we put words together to form phrases and sentences in English, how do we say them? Do we give equal importance to all the words that form a phrase or a sentence? In other words, do we stress all the words in a phrase or sentence? No, we don't. In a phrase or sentence (or in a longer piece of connected speech) we stress some of the words and leave the **others** unstressed. For example, in the phrase 'rice and curd' we stress the words 'rice' and 'curd' and leave the word 'and' unstressed. In the sentence 'I am a student' we stress only the word 'student' and leave the other words unstressed. The phrase and the sentence given above are reproduced below, this time with the stressed words marked with the vertical bar (').

10.8.1 Words to be Stressed in Connected Speech

'Rice and 'curd.

I am a 'student.

In the two examples given above we stressed certain words and left others unstressed. Are there any rules regarding which words we should stress in a piece of connected speech? Yes, there are. In fact, the meaning of the phrase or the sentence decides this. We stress those words in a phrase or sentence that are important for the meaning of the phrase or sentence.

10.8.2 Content Words and Grammatical Words

We said above that we stress those words that are important for the meaning. Let us illustrate this. In the sentence 'I love you' if the speaker wants to tell the person that he loves only the referred to person as 'you' and no one else, he will

stress the word ‘you’. If, on the other hand, the speaker wants to state that he (and no one else) loves that person, he will stress the word ‘I’. Look at the same sentence repeated twice below.

I love ‘you’ (The speaker loves that person ‘referred to as ‘you’ and none else)

‘I’ love you (The speaker, and none else, loves the person referred to as ‘you’)

What if the meaning doesn’t require any particular words in an utterance to be stressed? Then the speaker will stress the **content words** in an utterance and leave the **grammatical words** unstressed, e.g. I ‘love you. Now what are content and grammatical words?

Nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, question words and demonstrative are **content words,** that is, they have independent meanings of their own, and **articles, pronouns**, **prepositions, auxiliary verbs,** and **conjunctions** are **grammatical words,** that is, their main function is to show the grammatical relations among words. A few examples are given below, in which only the content words are stressed and the grammatical words are left unstressed. The stressed words are marked with the vertical bar.

I 'gave him 'ten 'books.

I 'love my 'friends.

I 'love to 'live in 'Delhi.

There are 'ten 'boys and 'five 'girls in our 'class.

My 'son is a 'good 'driver.

I 'ate some 'rice and 'curd.

We have a 'grey 'cat in our 'house.

'Give me 'six 'eggs, 'please.

In the examples given before, most of the content words are monosyllabic. What happens when a content word has more than one syllable? If a content word that has more than one syllable occurs in a piece of connected speech, we stress only that syllable in it which we stress if we were to say the word by itself. Here are a few examples in which the content words have more than one syllable each.

The 'coffee was 'excellent.

It was an 'excellent a'chievement.

I've made a mis'take

They have de'clared a 'holiday to'day.

Do you re'quire any as'sistance?

I will 'never for'get you.

We 'visited 'London last 'summer.

Is'lam is the re'ligion of 'Muslims.

I have an im'portant exami'nation to'morrow.

10.9 LET US SUM UP

This unit has introduced you to the types of customer you are likely to come across in your line of work. It has then gone on to tell you how best to deal with them, with a special focus on irate customers.

It has also given you many examples of phrases you should not use while handling customers and alternative phrases to replace these.

You have had the opportunity, in this unit, of extensive practice in the use of this type of language with plenty of exercises for practice. You have also learnt the use of modals, and their importance in questioning and in formal telephone conversation.

10.10 ANSWERS

Check your progress 1

1) i) I've only got a few minutes, so I need you to attend to me immediately. **Demanding**

   ii) Oh, you sound a lot like a friend of mine from Pune. Have you ever been to Pune? **Talkative**

   iii) Why don't we take this up another time? **Indecisive**

   iv) Can't you understand when someone tells you something once? **Rude**

   v) I don't think this will work. **Reluctant**

   vi) Never again will I ever use the services of your organization. **Irate**

   vii) It's working better now, but still not as I expected. **Dissatisfied**

   viii) Hmmm, perhaps. **Passive**

2) i) We could not furnish the details you asked for as we were short on staff. **Inappropriate**

   ii) You will have to wait two days to get this information. **Inappropriate**

   iii) I understand your concern….. **Appropriate**

   iv) That's not possible….. **Inappropriate**

   v) I'll certainly mail it to you by tomorrow. **Appropriate**

   vi) However, what I can do is…….. **Appropriate**

   vii) Our policy doesn't permit….. **Inappropriate**

   viii) That's not right…. **Inappropriate**

   ix) I can assure you that…….. **Appropriate**

   x) I can see you are upset…. **Appropriate**

   xi) I'm sorry you had to deal with this billing problem. I'll do whatever I can to help you. **Appropriate**

   xii) I really want to help you solve this problem with your order **Appropriate**

   xiii) I'm not sure we can do that. **Inappropriate**

   xiv) That must have been very difficult for you **Appropriate**

   xv) I think you should…. **Inappropriate**

Check your progress 2

The answers are given in **bold**.

i) You want some additional information to be able to solve a problem.

In order for me to assist you better I would need you to give me some more details.

ii) You want to offer the customer something new.

Would you be interested in seeing another version of this?

iii) You want to make an important point.

It's important that you familiarize yourself with the terms of the contract.

iv) You are offering to go into further detail.

May I explain this to you in greater detail?

v) You are offering to verify something.

I'll be happy to check it out for you.

vi) You want to paraphrase something to show your understanding of it.

So what you would like me to do is to waive the delivery charges.

vii) You want to give the example of another satisfied customer.

Some people have found this payment option helpful.

viii) You want to involve the customer in finding a solution to the problem.

How would you suggest we deal with this development?

ix) You want to assure your customer you empathize with him/her.

I understand why you feel this way.

x) You want to offer a solution

Here's what I can do. May I suggest an alternative?

Activity 2

Answers are given in **bold**.

i) What did you say?

I beg your pardon? / Could you repeat that?

ii) When did you last call us?

May I know/Would you happen to remember when you last called us?

iii) Can you give me your order number?

Could you give me/May I have your order number?

iv) What's your name?

May I have your name, please?

v) I'll see what I can do.

I assure you I'll do my best to help you in this matter.

vi) That's something I cannot do.

I'll tell you what I can do.

vii) The manager is not available at the moment.

I'm afraid the manager is not available at the moment. Why don't I ask him to call you as soon as he gets in?

viii) I'll call you tomorrow.

May I call you tomorrow? / Would it be alright if I called you tomorrow?

ix) I know you are not satisfied.

I can understand why you feel this way.

x) Is 2.30 p.m. on Friday okay?

Would 2.30 p.m. on Friday be okay?

Text for Audio

Types of Customer

There are as many types of customer as there are types of people. Also different customers have different sets of expectations from the products and services that they want to buy, or have bought. Both of these together determine the types of customer you are likely to deal with on a day-to-day basis.

Loud and aggressive customers can be very demanding and find it difficult to understand an opinion different from theirs. They are more than likely to make unreasonable requests, and the sooner they are pacified, the less is the danger of the exchange escalating to unpleasant heights. Use a calm and soothing tone of voice, and pacifying words like "Please", "I understand', and "I agree". Be assertive, but make sure nothing you say sounds remotely rude or aggressive.

Then there are the analytical, questioning types. They will carefully evaluate the pros and cons before making a decision, and ask a volley of questions, some relevant, some not so. See that you stick to logic, and make sure there are no loopholes in any solutions you offer. State facts and figures with care and precision. If in doubt, offer to transfer the call to somebody who can supply the more technical details.

The skeptical types are those who have a hard time trusting anything you say. Be prepared to buttress your points with all the data at your disposal, speak with conviction, choose your words with care, reassure them of full future support (and see that you provide it).

Be careful how you deal with the shy, timid ones. They tend to sound apologetic and unsure, and can be easily intimidated, so the first thing you need to do is make them feel comfortable. Probe gently for their needs, use an encouraging tone of voice, and assure them of your intentions with words like 'I'll be happy to do that for you'.

You also need to be especially careful with the technically aware customers. They tend to be somewhat impatient. These are straightforward people who need you to be honest about the advantages and disadvantages of what you are about

to offer, and have no patience with ambiguity or vagueness. Acknowledge the fact that they are technically well versed, but maintain a quietly assertive tone, for they can be a little overbearing. If unsure about some details, be candid and seek assistance immediately.

You will be pleased to come across the extroverts. They are talkative and friendly, and happy to part with any information you seek. Reciprocate the friendliness, but just be careful not to get side-tracked by too much chatter.

Then there are certain personal traits that make different people respond in varied ways. You will need to coax information out of the passive customers, a little like with the shy ones. With the chronic complainers you play the balancing act, admitting they are right where you need to and gently putting your foot down where they are unreasonable. The irate customer's temper is ready to explode, so be patient but firm. Those who constantly try to interrupt need to be told firmly that listening once in a while isn't a bad idea.

Check your progress 3

i) Be prepared with facts and figures – **Analytical, also Technically aware**

ii) Be encouraging and make them feel comfortable – **Shy, Introvert**

iii) Be friendly, but restrict getting side tracked - **Extroverts**

iv) Count to ten and stay cool – **Irate, also sometimes Aggressive**

v) Admit lack of awareness where necessary, and seek assistance - **Technically aware**

vi) Be patient as you may need to ask many questions to get some information – **Passive**

vii) Be firm to defend what is logically worth defending – **Chronic complainers**

viii) Be assertive, but use a calm, soothing tone of voice - **Aggressive**

ix) Use voice and words to speak with conviction - **Skeptical**

Activity 3

i) Good morning. How may I help you?

ii) Would you like to leave a message?

iii) This is Brinda Patel.

iv) May I speak to Mrs. Jones, please?

v) May I know what this is about?

vi) I'm afraid he's busy at the moment. / I'm afraid he isn't in office right now.

vii) Could/May I have your name, please?

viii) Could you repeat that, please?

Activity 4

Situation 1: This is only a sample conversation; yours could be different, but try to use the relevant phrases from the box in the Speaking section and/or from the Language Focus section.

Customer: Hello.

Executive: Good afternoon, Sir. This is Raman from XYZ Connections. I've called about an outstanding bill of yours.

Customer: As far as I can remember, there is no outstanding bill I need to pay. Please don't disturb me with these false bills.

Executive: I'm afraid there is. The outstanding amount is Rs.200, and it has been due for the last two months.

Customer: Can't you understand when someone tells you something once?

Executive: I understand what you are saying, but according to our records, a payment of Rs.200 is outstanding against your bill for the month of May.

Customer: Well, this is a late payment charge that I had been told would be waived when I spoke to your executive last month.

Executive: I'm afraid there is no such record of the waiver. However, here's what I can do. I'll……..

Situation 4: This is only a sample conversation; yours could be different, but try to use the relevant phrases from the box in the Speaking section and/or from the Language Focus section. Remember that you are speaking with a shy customer.

Customer: Hello?

Executive: Good afternoon. This is Manish, from Welcome Appliances. May I speak with Ms. Amrita Singh?

Customer: Yes. Err... This is she. Errr…errr… What is this about?

Executive: I hope I'm not disturbing you, but I need to remind you of a payment that is due. It's your installment for the month of March for the computer you bought in January.

Customer: So….. ummm……. Err…. When is this due?

Executive: I'm afraid it is already overdue by almost a month. And your next installment will be due too in another week.

Customer: Oh. Actually…….I don't know…(sounds embarrassed)

Executive: (Senses the hesitation) If you find this payment scheme inconvenient, may I make a suggestion….?

Customer: Yes…..okay.

Executive: What I can do is, I can split the payment……..

Activity 5

1) Completed sentences with *who, whom, which, that* and *to whom.*

   i) The receptionist at the desk **to whom** I spoke was very helpful.

ii) The hotel has a large conference hall in **which** workshops can be held.

iii) I can give you the name of the HR Manager **who/that** I deal with.

iv) We drew a shortlist of candidates **whose** CVs were very good.

v) We've got a machine **which/that** prints in colour.

vi) Yesterday I met someone **whose** brother works in your office.

vii) Our client manufacturers clothing **which** is distributed in the popular retail stores.

viii) We are looking for someone **who** has a proven track record of excellence.

2) Completed sentences using relative clauses.

i) I'm in a division **that handles the publicity**.

ii) I have a boss **who is very creative**.

iii) As part of my work, I deal with people **who are very talented**.

iv) I sometimes have to do jobs **that require me to work late into the night.**

v) In my free time, I enjoy doing things **that help me relax**.